H.I. Train Wreck

by Marie Pawelec



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SCENE ONE

H.I. COMPETITOR. (*doing vocal warm-ups*) Don't look at me. (*continues warming up, then turns to start piece*) I just want to start this thing off by saying I don't want to be here. I'm sure all of you can sympathize…(*at judge*) …especially you. I mean, you've probably got it worse than all of us. You are literally wasting your Saturday. You don't even get the benefit of a nice little extracurricular activity to go on a college résumé, or get to relive the fun, nerdy delights of high school, or even enjoy a consolatory Wendy's frosty on the way home. Nope, you get to wake up just as early as everyone else and sit in a chair forever. Plus, you're playing the lottery on how miserable you'll be while you're here. Will you get the joy of judging extemp? Oratory? Ooooh, maybe declamation! Luckily for you, dear judge, you landed DP! Enjoy the jealous looks of everyone else in the tab room who drew the short straw; I'm sure it's the only rewarding part of judging. And now, for your viewing pleasure, let's do a rundown of what you're going to see tonight over and over, and over. But first, I need to do my introduction. As if we ever really need those.

SCENE TWO

H.I. COMPETITOR. Ok, now that we got that scripted piece of garbage out of the way, we can get to the meaty chunk of regurgitated mess that you will have to suffer through for the next 8 or so minutes. You have 3 options. A: You can try to remain mildly interested in the remote hope that it will actually be funny. Two: Zone out and think how dumb acne-riddled high school teens look in formal business attire. Or C: Give up and take a nap. I don't mind. If you chose options "A" or "Two", I'm going to make this easier on you and give you a break down on all the characters I'm about to preform so you don't have to write on my ballot

JUDGE. (*writing*) Not enough...differentiation....between characters.

H.I. COMPETITOR. That's you, by the way. You're my first character.

STORYTELLER. (*laughs maniacally*) Hey friends! You best prepare your knees for slapping and your

guts for wrenching because my piece is hi-lar-i-ous! No really! I'm funny! My mommy told me! This is "The Three Little Pigs!'' (*laughs*) By that one guy!! (*laughs*) It's funny!

H.I. COMPETITOR. I'm also an attention seeker.

DECLAMATION SPKR. Hello. I'm about to stand up here for ten whole minutes and recite a poorly cut piece by an author whose name you'll have to ask for twice because when I speak, the monotony of my voice will make your head implode. If you're lucky I will go over-time. You will also be incredibly distracted by my pit stains.

D.I. COMPETITOR. Darkness. Depression. Edgar Allen Poe, the saddest man that ever lived once said, "Ouch, broken hearts suck.'' Ever since then, white girls like me have taken inspiration from legitimate tragedies to completely over-act in disturbing D.I.s that will cause you to go home and to look at pictures of cute puppies and silently sob at your computer. "Acid Face" by Susanne Buttkans.

NERVOUS COMPETITOR. Uhmm. Ok. Sorry??? Uhmm. Ok. Can I start over?

H.I. COMPETITOR. I know there's usually 6 people in a round, but I've already wasted 3 of your minutes and ain't nobody got time for that.

JUDGE. (*writing*) Three minutes have elapsed, (*writing slowly)* still not funny.

SCENE THREE

JUDGE. Whenever you're ready.

STORYTELLER. (*in gruff voice*) Once upon a time there was a big bad wolf! (*howls*) AWOOOOOOO! He was bad guy, so I'm going to talk like this.

JUDGE. I'm going to give you a three, because I feel bad for your parents.

STORYTELLER. There are also three sweet little pigs! Oink oink! There's a little onomatopoeia because that's the sound that pigs make!

JUDGE. Nobody loves you.

STORYTELLER. I know you know this story, but wait—plot twist—something really CRAAAAAZZZYYY HAPPENS!

JUDGE. I'm sorry, did you want time signals?

SCENE FOUR

D.I. COMPETITOR. (*intense)* I KNOW WHY YOU'RE HERE. IT'S BECAUSE IM A MONSTER! But I'm a person too. You'll see.

JUDGE. Wow, your eyebrows really make this piece.

D.I. COMPETITOR. NOW LISTEN TO THE DRAMATIC FLASH BACK OF MY PROGRESSION INTO MADNESS!

JUDGE. I wonder if this is about dead babies, murder, rape, or cancer.

D.I. COMPETITOR. My name is Suzy Lee. I look innocent, right? No one would ever guess that I'm a murderer!

JUDGE. Whoop, there it is!

D.I. COMPETITOR. I was a nice girl until my father did horrible things to me. Then my mother was diagnosed with cancer, my dog died, I broke every bone in my body, I got mugged in an alley by a one-hit wonder boy band, and I got stuck in traffic on the way to a BeeGee's concert!

JUDGE. I didn't even know that was possible to cram all of that into one plot line.

D.I. COMPETITOR. My emotions took control. I COULDN'T TAKE IT ANYMORE! THAT'S WHY I DID IT! That's why I killed Mufasa!

JUDGE. There is nothing I want more than to give you a swirly in the toilet but I'm going to have to give you a one, aren't I?

D.I. COMPETITOR. And thus, I die!

JUDGE. Ok, thank you.

SCENE FIVE

(*D.I. COMPETITOR 2 stands awkwardly.*)

JUDGE. Uhm, yes?

D.I. COMPETITOR 2. May I be excused?

JUDGE. Are you double entered?

D.I. COMPETITOR 2. No, I just want to practice my crying face in the bathroom.

JUDGE. Yes, please leave.

SCENE SIX

ORATORY COMPETITOR. (*nervous and stumbling over lines*) Hi, um, oh, sorry. I mean, hello, today we will be discussing how cultures, um today, um have pushed, uh, the superficial idea of beauty on today's youth. Today, and uh, my three points I will discuss are uh, all personal anecdotes uh, being, because I have lots of experience uh with this.

AUDIENCE MEMBER 1. (*fake cough)* Wrong room (*cough*)

AUDIENCE MEMBER 2. She doesn't even go here!

SCENE SEVEN

NERVOUS COMPETITOR. (*stands for a moment looking terrified)* Can I go throw up?

JUDGE. Yeah, go ahead.

SCENE EIGHT

D.I. COMPETITOR 3. Why would a woman want to be a detective? I don't know. I don't know a lot of things. What makes criminals tick? How could you kill someone in cold blood? Why does your car break down right after the warranty ends?

JUDGE. Please stop before I kill myself

D.I. COMPETITOR 3. (*immediately stops performing)* Ok.

JUDGE. (*surprised*) Really?

D.I. COMPETITOR 3. (*matter of fact*) Yeah

JUDGE. Oh, cool. (*referencing rank for the round*) Two?

SCENE NINE

(*Later, on the bus.*)

H.I. COMPETITOR. Wow, these ballots are ridiculous! (*reads comments*) "Nice diction, perfect characterization, very funny, nice job with intro, no stumbles. Overall perfect." (*smiles before reading the rank with shock*) SIXTH?!